Pearl Harbor

World War II officially began in the Pacific on December 7, 1941 when Japanese planes dropped bombs on the American Naval base at Pearl Harbor. Approximately 2400 soldiers were killed and more than 1100 others were wounded. The attacks came as a surprise because there was no formal declaration of war by Japan. Many Americans were stunned by the attack and were only consoled when President Roosevelt gave hope to them during his famous speech.

For years, China and Japan had been locked in a war, with neither side gaining any significant advantage. The Japanese seized the northern region of Manchuria, known today as the Heilongjiang, Liaoning and Jilin provinces. Japan was seeking to expand its territory and also launched other military campaigns in the Pacific region.